The Miner’s Boy

Erich Paul Honecker – General Secretary of the Socialist Unity Party of Germany, Chairman of the State Council, and Chairman of the National Defence Council – was born at number 26 Karlstrage in Neunkirchen at 6 pm on 25 August 1912. His birth certificate – issued five days later – shows both parents were Protestant and Erich, the ‘Sunday Child’, was also baptised as a Protestant.

Nowadays, little remains of the dusky black Saarland landscape where he first opened his eyes to the world – the coal basins and slag heaps have long gone. Back then, noise in this colliery town of 9,000 inhabitants began early in the day and continued long into the night: the creaking of coal wagons, the roar of steam turbines and the shriller outbursts of pit sirens filled the air.

As the son of a mine worker, Honecker’s roots were purely working-class. He was the fourth child of 31-year-old Wilhelm and 29-year-old Karoline, along with two brothers – Willi and Karl-Robert – and three sisters, Katharina, Frieda and Gertrud.

His parents – although not given to overt displays of affection – were a devoted union and enjoyed a strong happy marriage. It was perhaps inevitable, then, that Erich looked back affectionately on his childhood, as part of a large, loving, close-knit family. He was proud of his Saarland heritage and never lost the accent or memories of his upbringing in a tiny two-up two-down in Wiebelskirchen, a northern suburb of Neunkirchen. The region was once part of the French Lorraine district, which came to France in the eighteenth century – then back to Germany following its annexation after Waterloo. Like most kids, Erich Honecker took his surroundings in his stride and found them unexceptional. At home, there was no hot water, the family shared an outside lavatory, gas-lit the bedrooms and there was no electricity. ‘On the ground floor there were two rooms with a door in the middle,’ Honecker recounted. ‘On the second floor